There was much debate across nations whether measures imposed were draconian or not. Could folks be penalized for not following sanitary, lockdown and hygiene rules? Could governments enforce countrymen to wear masks? Could governments track infected people on CCTV for contact tracing without violating their right to privacy? How far could governments go in order to keep their people safe while also protecting human rights and their right to privacy?

Back home, there was no doubt on Lok Kalyan Marg that the prime minister would have to make some tough choices. Unless strict rules and stringent enforcement were the focus in policymaking—looking at our sheer numbers, demographic, the urban–rural divide, rampant illiteracy and compromised hygiene—lakhs of Indian lives would be lost. The only other leader in the history of India who had run historic mobilization campaigns with an emphasis on hygiene and sanitation was Mahatma Gandhi. Although the prime minister initiated and ran a successful Swachh Bharat Abhiyan (Clean India Mission) during his first term, with a goal to increase access to toilets and make the country open-defecation free, the kind of mobilization which would be required to ask people to make urgent behavioural modifications could not be compared to any recent initiatives in the history of modern, independent India.